



**P**eople live and die for ideas. Freedom was an idea which created the Republic of India. Communism was an idea which captured the imagination of half the world and its stepchild, socialism, still has currency. Capitalism is, of course, the idea which has driven the developed world. The big ideas are frequently the blueprints for a society's development. It is the beginning from which action springs. However, ideas cannot be static. They must evolve and change with circumstances. In fact, societies that remain entrapped in an idea often fail.

For almost half a century since Independence, India was embroiled in the idea of socialism and non-alignment for which we are still suffering the consequences. Since the 1990s, India has tried to shed the dead-weight of a command economy and opened itself to a new globalised world.

There's a great churning happening in India in almost every field as we attempt to modernise and provide a decent living to our citizens. In today's fast-changing, inter-connected and technology-driven world, what are the ideas that can transform India and how can they be implemented? These are the questions we attempt to answer in the second edition of the Spirit of India series with the finest minds from a wide range of fields.

The issue features 33 articles from an array of industrialists, management gurus, scientists and academics. Lakshmi Mittal is better known for building a steel empire, yet he is concerned about the state of Indian sport. He has written about how India can emulate China's Olympic success, using sports to foster a spirit of nationalism and create a healthy community. N.R. Narayana Murthy has spent a vast amount of time and energy building an IT behemoth, yet his concern for replacing the idea of reservations in the corporate sector with mission-oriented training programmes is worth emulating. Again, Azim

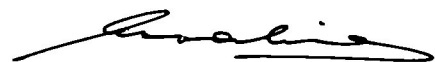
Premji, one of the wealthiest men in the world with assets of over \$12 billion, has a big idea that is as astonishing in its simplicity as it is in practicality. Convert every government school into a centre for excellence and make every Indian proud to send his children there.

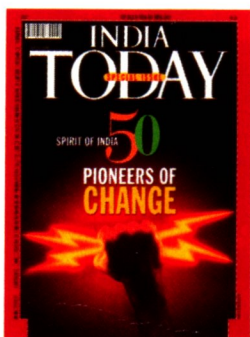
From management guru C. K. Prahalad's belief that the poor don't need charity but the opportunity for entrepreneurship to green whiz Rajendra Pachauri's insistence that India can lead the world in solar energy, the issue has a wealth of ideas that inspire.

Some of our columnists, such as McKinsey's Rajat Gupta, bring to the issue a depth of international experience in forging public-private partnerships. He believes in a joint effort to make healthcare accessible to all. Others, such as Delhi Metro Rail Corporation's E. Sreedharan, infuse a breath of hard-as-nails knowledge, gained from years of handling political ineptitude. He believes that a metro revolution will resolve most of urban India's traffic problems.

Historian Sanjay Subrahmanyam has dug deep into our past to signal philanthropy as the big idea while Sam Pitroda, who knows a thing or two about revolutions, believes the nature of teaching in schools has to change. From writer Siddharth D. Shanghvi, who believes citizens have to assert themselves to make a corrupt system work, to economist Tarun Khanna, who insists that the private sector needs to act as a catalyst for the public sector, there is a plethora of big ideas that alert policy planners should immediately implement.

In the new attention economy, if an idea can grab mindspace, that's half the work done. Those who have written for the special issue have done their bit. The other half is to actually do it. And if there's one message in this issue, it is this. The change begins from everyone of us, whether it is a question of voting, of volunteering or even of voicing our opinion against a wrongdoing. Remember, the most effective way to cope with change is to help create it.

  
(Aron Purie)



**Spirit of India: The first**  
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